READING SKILLS

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- A simple (and provisional) definition of **reading** is that it is a process whereby one looks at and understands what has been written.
- Reading involves many sub skills for example: literal comprehension, inferential comprehension, interpretation, evaluation and critical appreciation.
- The process of reading has the following **characteristics**:

1. It is both a physical and mental activity.
2. It requires attention and thought.

3. It involves the participation of the reader emotionally and intellectually.

4. It involves interpretation of the written (printed) symbols.

- Different readers may interpret the same text differently. This implies that readers put meaning into what they read.
- The meaning that a reader may put on a piece of writing is determined by several factors.
- For example, the reader's background, knowledge or experience, emotional appeal of the subject or the reader's intellectual ability

APPROACHES TO READING

A) **Appreciative**

- Reading for pleasure/entertainment

B) **Comprehension**

- Acquiring knowledge and information: to be informed about the world you live in.

C) **Critical Reading**

- Reading for academic purpose. Materials that can be read for academic information are: textbooks, reference books, general and specialist journals, magazines and special sections of newspapers.

BASIC READING TECHNIQUES

a) **Surveying/Previewing**

- It is a pre-reading activity which involves reading to obtain a general idea of the contents, and predicting what will come next or how the text will develop
- It helps the reader to predict in a very short time, what a reading text is all about and to determine its degree of relevance.
- The reader can decide whether to read the book or not, or whether to read a part or parts of it and which part.

- Previewing a text is done by looking at the following:

i) Front matter: title, forward/preface or introduction, table of contents.

ii) Back matter: blurbs, index, glossary, bibliography.

iii) The book itself: Headings, subheadings, organizations, language, content, diagrams.

b) **Skimming**

- It is used when a reader wants to get the main idea or gist of a text within a very short time.
- When skimming, you need to read the topic sentences only.
- The topic sentence is usually the first in a paragraph and expresses the main idea.
- But sometimes a writer may choose to make the second sentence of a paragraph the topic sentence.

c) Scanning.

- It involves searching for particular items of information.
- You are interested in these items only and not everything in the text.

d) Word by word reading

- This reading technique is used when one is learning how to read for the first time.
- Word for word reading means trying to understand fully one word or phrase at a time. It is a slow reading technique. Scientists and mathematicians use it when they are studying processes and formulae.

d) Intensive reading

Intensive reading entails content study of what is read in some detail and study of language in which the material is written. Intensive reading calls for a deep and thorough understanding of what is written.

Intensive reading implies approaching a text under the guidance of a task (or a teacher) which forces the student to use analytical, critical and evaluative skills. It is the type of reading a university student engages in when studying

- To be an efficient intensive reader, you need to get rid of some bad reading habits:

i) Trying to understand every word that you read by consulting the dictionary from time to time. Interferes with concentration.

ii) Vocalization or moving lips as you read. This slows down reading to a speaking pace and is therefore inefficient.

iii) Retrogression. This means reading forwards and backwards. It hinders comprehension unless you are doing word by word reading.

iv) Pointing - using a finger, pencil or pen over what is being read or nodding the head. This is not only slow but also clumsy

The **SQ3R** reading method

- The abbreviation SQ3R stands for the steps that one reader follows while using this method of reading. These are; **S**urvey, **Q**uestion, **R**ead, **R**evise and **R**ecite.

i) Survey

- Glance over the titles or chapter headings to establish the subject of the text.
- Read the whole of the first paragraph; in case of a passage.
- Read the first sentence in each subsequent paragraph
- Read the whole of the last paragraph
- In case of a book, read chapter summaries or conclusions.

ii) Question

- Turn the first heading into a question. This will arouse your curiosity and thereby increase your comprehension.
- The question will also make important points stand out, at the same time, explanatory details will be recognised.
- In case of passages or even some books, you could also look at the questions in the text.

iii) Read

Read the text to establish the subject matter, the writer's approach and get the general gist. Try to obtain quick answers for the questions you raised in (ii) above.

iv) Revise

- At this stage, you get into active reading and search for information and answers to specific questions.
- You have to make notes. You should be guided by the topic sentences and the supporting evidence as well as the discourse markers (idea connectors). They will show you the trend of argument of the author.

v) Recite

- Having read and revised, now look away from the text and try to recall and recite the answers to the questions raised or thought about.

- Use your own words and cite some examples
- If you can recite, you know what is in the book; if you can't glance over the section again.
- An excellent way to recite from memory is to write down brief notes or phrases in outline form, on a piece of paper.

MURDER Reading Strategy

- MURDER method was first introduced by Danserau et al. in 1979 (Hayes, 1981).
- The acronym of MURDER itself is Mood, Understand, Recall, Detect, Elaborate and Review.
- It is an alternative method which enables the students comprehend reading texts, particularly narrative texts, by collaboration working between two groups.

Steps in MURDER Strategy

a) Mood

- Teacher divides the students into two members/groups (recaller and detector). Each group sets a relaxed purposeful mood before beginning their work.
- They make sure they are clear on the procedure to follow and to engage in a little chit-chat

b) Understand:

- Teacher divides the text into sections, each group should understand the first section by reading silently.

c) Recall

- The recaller group summarizes the main ideas without looking at the text.

d) Detect

- The detector group listens for the errors or omission in the recaller's summary and discusses these with the recaller member.
- The role of recaller and detector rotate for the next section.

e) Elaborate

- Both groups elaborate on the ideas in the section. The types of elaborations include the following:

1. Connections with other thing the students have studied
2. Links between the section and students' lives.
3. Opinions with the view or ideas expressed the section.
4. Reaction to the section such as gladness, anger, or sadness.
5. Applications for the ideas and information.
6. Questions either about things not understood or questions sparked by the section.

The groups repeat the Understand, Recall, Detect and Elaborate step for all sections of the text.

f) Review

- Both groups combine their thoughts to summarize the entire text after completing all the sections

TEXT READABILITY

- This is the extent to which it is possible to read a text and comprehend its content.
- It refers to the relative simplicity or difficulty in understanding, interpreting, evaluating or applying the information in a text.

Factors determining text readability

a) The language level.

- This includes new words and other technical or scientific terms which one is not familiar with.
- It may also refer to sentence structures, stylistic devices, register, idiomatic expressions used etc.

b) Content

- This refers to the subject matter. It could be elementary or advanced depending on the level of education of the reader.

c) Layout

- This is the arrangement or structure of the text in terms of chapters, units, paragraphs and even sentences.
- The way a text is structured makes it possible to follow the trend of though of the writer.

Comprehending a Difficult Text

a) Vocabulary

- One can understand new words, difficult terms, phrases or expressions without using a dictionary.
- This can be done by: -looking at the context clues, getting synonyms, using predictions and using inference

b) Predictions

- This is when one reads to confirm expectations. This technique is highly motivating and gives one a purpose for reading.

c) Inference/implications (“reading between the lines”)

- This is 'reading' beyond what you can see in print, on pages. It calls for reasoning, reaching an opinion, making conclusions.
- It is important when answering questions on meanings of words, phrases as used in the passage and also identification of the connotations of different sentences.